



Management's Letter To Partners

Dear Partners,

I hope all is well and that you've had a good start to 2026.

2025 PERFORMANCE

In 2025, the Aquamarine Fund returned **11.3%**, compared to 17.9% for the S&P 500. Since the fund's inception in September 1997, our capital has compounded at a rate of **9.4%** annually, versus 9.2% for the S&P 500, 9.0% for the Dow Jones Industrial Average, 8.0% for the MSCI World, and 4.8% for the FTSE 100.

The Aquamarine Fund's total return from inception is **1185.6%**, compared with 1103.4% for the S&P 500, 779.8% for the MSCI World, and 280.6% for the FTSE 100.

For investors in our zero-management-fee share classes, performance since inception has been materially higher than that of the original share class, reflecting the absence of ongoing management fees. Since its launch on November 1, 2009, the 1-year zero-management-fee share class has delivered a cumulative return of **434.4%**, compared with 402.0% for the original share class over the same period. The 2-year zero-management-fee share class has returned **104.4%** since its inception on December 1, 2017, versus 85.8% for the original share class over the corresponding timeframe. Similarly, the 5-year zero-management-fee share class has compounded at **113.1%** since its inception on November 1, 2017, compared with 86.1% for the original share class. These differences are driven primarily by the fee structure rather than portfolio construction, as all share classes participate in the same underlying portfolio.

The contributors in returns in 2025 came from BYD Co Ltd, American Express Co, and Bank of America Corp. The main detractors were Ferrari NV, Indian Energy Exchange Ltd, and Exor NV.

Since my decision to close down the fund and to return outside capital, our cash has increased to approximately **50%** of the **\$470 million** or so AUM.

RETURN OF CAPITAL

This is not the letter I wanted to be writing—but it's the one I have to write.

As you know, we are returning outside capital and winding down Aquamarine Fund for external investors. This decision is not about performance or about the markets or timing. It's about my health—and my obligation to treat your capital with the seriousness it deserves.

For most of my adult life, I imagined a very long runway. With 28 years of managing Aquamarine behind me, I expected to follow my hero Warren Buffett and keep going for another three decades—long enough to build a 60-year record and fully harness the power of compounding.

I believed that, with your help, I could build something of lasting value that I would be proud of. Perhaps not quite Berkshire Hathaway, but a Zürich twin. “Klein aber fein,” small but beautiful, as one would say in German. Moreover we were well on our way. I had the right team in place, and with \$470 million in assets under management, we were developing the momentum I had always aimed for, but as the Yiddish proverb says, “Der mentsh trakht und gott lakht”. Man plans and God laughs. Or, in the words of Mike Tyson, “Everybody has a plan until they get punched in the mouth.”

My punch in the mouth came in late November 2024. Snow had come early to Klosters and I had spent the day skiing with my children, but on the drive back to Zürich, I suffered a grand mal seizure, otherwise known as an epileptic fit.

It came with no warning. There were no prior symptoms or indications—nothing. We were extremely fortunate that my wife, Lory, was driving. Had I been at the wheel, it could have meant death for me, Lory and Sarah our daughter—not to mention causing a traffic pile-up that could have hurt or killed many more.

An MRI at Hirslanden Hospital revealed a small tumor in my head in a location that was considered safe to remove. Four days later I was in surgery for a craniotomy and the tumor was completely resected. Despite the small size and the benign appearance, the histology confirmed grade 4 glioblastoma, or GBM.

As this is Switzerland, I was moved quickly to what is the standard-of-care for GBM—known as the Stupp protocol: A course of radiotherapy and chemotherapy starting on December 23, 2024 and finishing on my birthday, February 4, 2025. Some of you also saw me wearing an Optune device in the hope that it would prevent recurrence.

The tumor was small, the doctors caught it early, and I immediately underwent the appropriate treatment, so my chances of beating the worst outcomes were good, and I continued my life as normal. However, that changed in September 2025 with an unclear MRI and minor (or focal) seizures. These led to a second craniotomy and the conclusion that the cancer had returned.

This recurrence changed the calculus for Aquamarine Fund. Previously, I could have every hope and expectation that the cancer was in remission and that my top priority of compounding our capital could remain unchanged. The recurrence meant I could no longer say that.

Although my mind and investing abilities remain intact today, we have no way of knowing when that might change. My condition could stabilize for a long time, or it might not. While I

continue to have every hope of living a long and productive life, that is less likely than before. The range of outcomes has widened considerably. Faced with that uncertainty, I knew I had to reprioritize my life.

Up to this point, despite my many outside interests, my top priority was to continue to compound your capital at Aquamarine Fund. This is no longer the case. My top priority has become my health and spending precious time with my family.

My initial thought was to offer you, the outside investors, a choice: A return of capital for those who wanted it, and to allow others to remain invested. However, after seeking counsel from my family, the team, our directors, legal advisors, and close friends, I received the clear message that it would be far better to return the money now and end my investing career on a good note.

So we decided that the best course was to return the outside capital now, while the fund is up and we are ahead. It is far better to conclude a career on a high note than to risk a period of decline—mental or financial—that could lead to recriminations or a loss of the trust we have spent decades building. The board also felt that stepping back might bring me less stress and more calm. I'm not sure yet if they're right—I liked my life the way it was.

This was not my first choice, and I take this step reluctantly. It was a decision forced by medical circumstances, not by a lack of faith in the markets or our strategy. While I cannot change my diagnosis, I can control how I respond to it. The only honorable path is to act with transparency and protect your interests before any possible decline occurs.

As Warren Buffett noted in his recent letter, so much in life—and in investing—depends on luck. I have been lucky in so many ways: To have survived that drive from Klosters; to have had 28 wonderful years managing this fund; and most of all, to have had your trust.

Winding down the fund does not sit easily with me but I do it with a heart full of gratitude rather than regret. I have valued each of you—for your trust, your patience, and your belief in me and my team. That trust made everything possible. It was, and is, the foundation.

LIQUIDATING THE PORTFOLIO

Once we had taken the decision, we knew that we would need to raise \$235 million in order to meet all the cash returns to investors at the end of the year. So I sat down with David and mapped out what I wanted the portfolio to look like as of year-end. We have always kept the portfolio in liquid securities that were easy to price and liquidate if we had to. We have also kept an updated “days to liquidation” analysis for risk-management purposes. I've always wanted us to be able to liquidate the portfolio easily if necessary. In other words, I always kept an eye on the possibility that an unexpected rainy day was just around the corner.

That meant that David could go about an orderly liquidation of approximately half the portfolio in order to deliver the cash to you. We've sold what we needed to sell to meet the year-end redemption requests and to return capital to investors. David executed the trades through Sanford Bernstein and IIFL Capital.

This wasn't a difficult process. With the exception of one security, Seritage Growth Properties,

which took a little longer to sell down without impacting the price, we had no liquidity issues. We were able to sell the shares we needed to without the sales becoming a meaningful proportion of daily volume.

David also reviewed execution closely. The vast majority of trades were done at VWAP (volume-weighted average price), or within a very tight tolerance of the VWAP. The goal was to make sure we weren't being disadvantaged by brokers during the liquidation.

This was the largest liquidation I'm ever likely to do. We paid the highest aggregate brokerage fees we've ever paid in Aquamarine's history—yet they were in the order of less than 10 basis points, which is reasonable.

At year-end, we will strike a NAV as usual with SS&C. Your holdings will be converted into contract notes and, once we have the go-ahead, we will begin sending funds back. There will be a holdback, as required, until after the audit by Deloitte has been completed to address any issues that might arise. I don't expect there to be any.

This is probably the most significant thing we ever do, and Team Aquamarine's reputation will hang on getting it right. I know Chantal and David have followed up with every single investor. We want to ensure funds are sent to the correct destination and that all AML procedures are in place. I believe this will run like clockwork, Swiss-style.

A RETROSPECTIVE PORTFOLIO REVIEW

I've been looking back and this feels like a significant milestone for me—a turning point. It's not one I would have chosen but I'm determined to make the most of it. Below is a review of the companies that have been in the portfolio. It's not complete; perhaps at some point I'll do a more comprehensive analysis.

You can't just total up dollars lost or gained. To get a full picture you need to consider what impact each position had on the portfolio at the time, so this is really just a rough picture of where the returns came from.

Overall, I've had fewer than 200 companies in the portfolio. Most of those were very small positions where, in order to really learn about a company and the surrounding industry, I had to own it.

For better or worse, I came to managing Aquamarine Fund with no direct experience in investing. I did have a background in economics, management consulting, an MBA, and investment banking—but I needed to learn on the job.

Thankfully, I had the best teachers. First and foremost were Warren Buffett and Charlie Munger, but there were many others in the mix, including Ruane Cunniff, Lou Simpson, Tom Russo, Tweedy Browne partners, Peter Cundill, Tom Gayner, Nick Sleep, Mohnish Pabrai, Li Lu, and more recently the amazing participants in the VALUEx conference. I read their letters, attended their meetings, and watched what they did with their capital.

I looked to reverse-engineer their thinking and where I thought that I could understand their reasons, I invested. I also looked for similar companies in emerging markets and elsewhere that

bore the same characteristics. Most of my investments came from this style of thinking.

It led me to many of the businesses that produced most of the 12X result. For example, from Tom Russo I learned about the power of brands, which resulted in successful investments in Nestlé, Weetabix, Alaska Milk, Heineken, and McDonald's. Through Girish Bhakoo I learned about the credit rating business, with investments in Duff & Phelps, Moody's, CRISIL, and CareEdge Ratings. Through Berkshire Hathaway I learned about insurance, which led to investing in Berkshire Hathaway, RLI Insurance, Aflac, American Safety Insurance, and AIG.

I also reasoned beyond the insights I gained from studying the moves of others. I realized that a branded education was not dissimilar to a credit rating on bonds, but on people, so, at one time I had a large commitment to the for-profit education sector, with significant investments in DeVry, Apollo Education, and Interboro College (through EVCI Career Colleges). I also went international, investing in Raffles Education Corporation in Singapore, Far Eastern Education Corporation in the Philippines, Majan University College in Oman, and Anhanguera Educacional and Estácio Participações in Brazil.

I invested in Eurotunnel bonds after understanding the power of monopoly toll bridges, and that led to investments in other kinds of financial infrastructure and payment systems: Investment Technology Group, Knight Trading, Western Union and MoneyGram, Freddie Mac, Mastercard, Indian Energy Exchange, and American Express.

There were plenty of mistakes of various kinds along the way. Sometimes I sold out way too soon: CRISIL, for example, in which I turned what could have been a potential 200X+ return into a mere 7-bagger. I also did not manage to hold on to Aflac, Discover Financial Services, Moutai, Liberty Media, and McDonald's, despite their being fine compounding machines.

At times, I was spooked out of the name at the wrong time. One example is Moody's in the aftermath of the 2008 financial crisis, for fear of litigation. In the case of LabCorp of America, I missed out on 200X for fear of insolvency that never materialized.

More than once I was lucky to have made the money that I did. It was only in retrospect that I realized I'd been running through a bomb factory with a lit match. Although I made a lot of money in the for-profit education space—Raffles Education, DeVry, and EVCI Career Colleges were multi-bagger exits for me—I was constantly running the risk of adverse regulations from the government. It was by dint of pure luck that I sold out of my US for-profit colleges before the election of President Obama in 2008, which all but destroyed the sector. Similarly, I sold out of Freddie Mac not because I was smart, but simply because I questioned. If Warren and Charlie thought that their underwriting was no longer risk-averse and at the same time smart people like Michael Burry and Bill Ackman were betting against the housing market, I had no business being long.

There were positions that were simply “dead money.” The game was set up in such a way that although I was unlikely to lose a lot, I was unlikely to win. That was the case with the Brazilian, Omani, and Filipino education companies, and with Eurotunnel, which represented too juicy a financial opportunity for the banks not to take advantage of the bondholders.

One area in which I made decent money but wish that I'd never entered is resource extraction—mining and related investments. In this area the investments range from Fortescue Metals Group

in Australia to London Mining, Cresud in Argentina, Potash Corporation of Saskatchewan, Jordan Phosphates, Teekay Offshore, and a few others.

These businesses are cyclical, with boom-and-bust cycles, but to the investor they always look as if they are about to turn non-cyclical and become endless profitable money machines. This rarely happens. That said, there is money to be made in these businesses but it requires very careful study and insider-like knowledge, and on top of that, impeccable timing. In my case this culminated with my largest portfolio loss—Horsehead Holding—but it was largely neutralized by the big wins in Fortescue, London Mining, and Micron Technology.

When one looks at the bucket as a whole, one sees a lot of activity for not much gain. The portfolio activity was bad enough but what I really regret is the time spent thinking about the space: What the marginal cost curve is; which mines are, or might be, coming online; how demand might decline if there is a recession; who has the balance sheet strength to see it through and who doesn't. All of this is ephemeral knowledge with a short half-life. Even if there is money to be made, there are better ways to spend one's time. If I were starting my investment career from scratch, I'd leave it to someone who wants to play the resource-extraction game.

Then there are many mistakes of omission—where the company was right there and I had the analysis at hand but I did not act. Over a Cornish pasty on the King's Road, Nick Sleep and Qais Zakaria shared their analysis of Amazon and Costco. I did not bite. Although I understood the economics of credit ratings, payment systems, and financial exchanges, I never invested in Visa, S&P Global, MSCI, or any of the big financial exchanges like the New York Stock Exchange, CBOE, and others.

There was also a meaningful number of companies in which I bought a few shares, held them for a while, and sold them—not making a lot of money, not losing a lot of money, but getting educated along the way. I learned more about the business and a bit more about how to invest. They weren't winners or losers; there was just some money tied up in a company for a time.

The good news of course is that I got plenty enough right, with enough winners for one investing career to make a financial difference to the lives of my investors and my family.

WITH WHOM I WOULD INVEST

After the capital has been returned, we will become a family office and my challenge will mirror yours: Where to invest. Without making recommendations, I wanted to share the framework that I will be using to manage my family's money.

Some time ago, I wrote up the criteria that I would use in selecting stewards of our capital if I were not doing the job. Now that I am focusing on my health, I will be using these myself.

It comes down to five key characteristics.

1. Investing their own money, or skin in the game

To get around the principal-agent problem you want a manager who thinks like an owner. I want someone who is investing their own money alongside yours and who thinks about investments the way you would.

That's very hard, because the people lining up to manage your hard-earned money—a

banker, an advisor, or some other “investment professional”—will have interests that are not entirely aligned, if at all. They may want to grow the AUM; they may even be compensated that way, or on new fund inflows; or perhaps they are simply chasing a promotion.

There's a well-known story in my family of my father meeting with his bank manager at UBS. The bank manager had invested my father's portfolio in a selection of the Standard & Poor's 500. The bank manager himself personally owned shares of Berkshire Hathaway but he didn't think to include them in my father's portfolio. In fact, he was not allowed to. That's a prime example of misaligned interests.

That also goes for the manager of a publicly traded company.

A useful example: I used to own shares and was very interested in Harley-Davidson. Jochen Zeitz took a large options package to see if he could turn around the company's fortunes. Even though he was a highly talented and capable manager who did impressive work at Puma, his incentives still weren't fully aligned.

By contrast, Warren Buffett has spent all of his professional time running Berkshire Hathaway. He did not have a side gig running a VC fund or some other get-rich-quick (or quicker) scheme.

There are plenty of situations in which we have to deal with people whose interests aren't aligned: Lawyers, investment bankers, real estate agents, but as Charlie Munger used to say, you need to apply windage factor. When it comes to managing my money, I not only want someone investing their own money, I want their money alongside mine—ideally in the same portfolio and accounted for in the same way.

2. Their primary or sole focus

The second point is that it should be their primary—or sole—focus. Put all your eggs in one basket and then watch the basket. I don't want somebody who's doing this as a side gig or a hobby, or like the person I was talking about at Harley-Davidson, who's doing this for upside but has little downside. Not only has it got to be their primary activity, it's got to involve most if not all of their net worth. I similarly don't want someone who runs plenty of parallel portfolios and puts me into one of them. If it has to be part of a group of companies, like, for example, John Malone's Liberty Media, it should be in the mothership.

Take these examples from the luxury goods industry: Georges Kern may not succeed as much as he would like to, but you can be sure that he's 100% focused on Breitling, and that his financial interests are closely tied to it. Similarly, Bernard Arnault's wealth is closely tied to LVMH. John Elkann's is tied to Exor. Johann Rupert's is tied to Compagnie Financière Richemont. Those, for example, all meet that criterion of being a primary or sole focus, as opposed to somebody who's running three funds.

Chris Hohn runs a highly focused operation, as I did. I didn't have multiple portfolios, a venture capital arm over here and a high-value strategy over there. I just had one focus.

3. Do it as an activity not as a business

Some things work really well as a business. If you're making a product, like Coca-Cola or an automobile, then you want to run it as a business, but the problem with running money

as a business is that pressures and conflicts of interest build up inside the business. Then it becomes too easy to make money not with your investors, but off your investors. That happens because you can develop very, very nice fee income streams, and that doesn't align interests. Most money managers, especially the big professional corporate money managers, are doing just that. They're asset-gathering; they're not running money as if it were theirs. One of the ways I avoided this was to charge no management fees and have a cumulative hurdle.

So managing investors' money should be done as an activity, not as a business.

4. Be good at it—demonstrable competence and candor

Obviously, they should be good at it, and over time they should write a letter explaining what they've done. They'll certainly make mistakes but you should be able to see—both from the numbers and from the way they write about what they've done—that they are at least likely to be good at it.

Somebody who keeps starting new funds; somebody whose fund is always very young; somebody who makes excuses; somebody who doesn't provide a rational reason for underperformance; and somebody who doesn't describe their mistakes accurately and learn the lessons from them is unlikely to be good at it.

5. Fiduciary gene

This is the most critical. Without it, you can forget about the first four. They need to have the fiduciary gene. They must want a good reputation and to be fair with investors, for the simple reason that this is how they want to play the game of life. That has to be more important than how much money they make. Some people are just all about the money and some people are not.

You can usually tell the difference pretty easily.

I will be keeping a list of those publicly traded companies and private partnerships that will go into our portfolio in the event of my untimely demise.

It is not appropriate for me to go into it here because we are regulated and it might be construed as providing financial advice, but the "With Whom I Would Invest" document is available online. I will continue to write a letter for my family in which I will share insights, and you are welcome to receive it.

MY YEAR-END PORTFOLIO

As you can see from the results over the last year the value of the portfolio and its evolution have little or indeed nothing to do with my health. Thankfully.

That has been by design for a long time.

A decade ago, I realized I needed to be as comfortable with my investments when I was away from my desk as when I was at it. I was on a long-distance flight on an investment-research trip, and I realized that I thought very differently about Heineken (then in the portfolio) and Nestlé than I did about other companies, where the outcome was more uncertain.

I began shifting away from “binary” outcomes—where the range of results is wide and uncertain—and toward durable or time-friendly compounders, where time is our friend and the range of outcomes runs from “decent” to “superb” with a very low chance of permanent loss.

That is where the portfolio is already positioned and many of the names are inevitable (as Warren Buffett might call them) and familiar to you—Berkshire Hathaway, Mastercard, American Express, Nestlé, Moody's, and others.

You can also expect me, over time, to exit investments where there is more of a binary outcome. Companies where outcomes are less certain, like India Energy Exchange, will likely be de-emphasized or removed.

By contrast, expect me to concentrate on companies where they can rinse, repeat, and grind through. Berkshire Hathaway, for example, now sits on \$350 billion in cash, quietly doing incremental acquisitions—most recently, Occidental's petrochemicals business. As with other “glacial moves” (like swapping Procter & Gamble shares for Duracell), these are subtle but accretive deals, the benefits accruing steadily to Berkshire. Even the much-questioned Kraft Heinz will, in time, likely accrue value to Berkshire.

Similarly with BYD, the thesis is simple. It has the most integrated operations and lowest costs. Yes, there is currently a price war but that means that BYD can drive much-needed consolidation in China and perhaps beyond. Moreover, with its low-cost structure, BYD can choose to return the industry to profitability when it wants.

We might own some and study others but whether they're credit rating agencies, luxury names like Ferrari and LVMH, or categories I've studied for years, such as elevators and the unglamorous, cash-generating carpeting and flooring industry, the thread is the same: Wait long enough and you win—maybe a lot, maybe a little, but you win.

The blessing, if there is any, in being forced to devote more of my time to health, is that this long-term, low-maintenance investment approach fits perfectly. I am well prepared for this moment, and confident in telling my family and like-minded investors that, provided you accept my health may from time to time require focus, you are riding alongside me in a strategy built for durable, compounding outcomes.

This shift may even improve return; when I observe Chris Hohn's very focused portfolio, for example, his returns have exceeded mine.

FUND ORGANIZATION GOING FORWARDS

We have a great team in place, consisting of Chantal, David, Mariana, and Paaras. They have committed to the transition, or should I say evolution, to a family office.

One of the advantages of the zero management-fee structure where the related shareholders pay an increased management fee is that we do not have to restructure our expenses at Aquamarine and things will continue to run as they have.

Moreover, my plan is to continue with my investing activities. VALUEx in particular will be a place where I will meet managers and perhaps invest with them—as other invitees have. I will also learn about new investment ideas and potentially partner up with other attendees of VALUEx in exploiting special situations with a small part of the portfolio.

I continue to hold you, my former investors, in high regard. Consider yourselves as members of my extended family. We will do our best to welcome you at VALUEx and we will try to help with other invitations and access as we can.

BEING OPEN ABOUT MY GBM

In this letter I have been explicit about what I've got. I'm doing that deliberately. Although I'm not a public figure like Warren Buffett, or a very famous figure, I'm not unfamous either. People know who I am and I believe there is a strategic reason to be open.

If you have a disease that is common enough—or one that allows people to live for a long time—a large interest group naturally forms around it. In the case of glioblastoma (GBM) we face a two-pronged problem. On the one hand it counts as a rare disease, with an incidence of 3–4 per 100,000 of population in developed countries.

At the same time, the life expectancy remains short. While there have been many advances in oncology over the last 20 years, not much progress has been made with brain cancer. Most of the anti-cancer therapies don't work in the brain because of the blood-brain barrier. Like the placenta, which limits what enters the fetus, there are many larger molecules that the blood-brain barrier does not let into the brain—which is one reason why GBM remains so difficult to treat.

So, we face a “bathtub” problem. If a disease is particularly rare or has a short lifespan—and both are true for GBM—there isn't much “water” going into the tub, and there is a big drain on the other side. This means that at any one time, there isn't a large focus group to drive solutions.

Yet for a disease that is statistically rare, GBM has touched my own world with startling frequency. About 10 years ago, while standing in line to enter the TED theatre in Long Beach, I struck up a conversation with the artist Janet Echelman. We discovered that her husband, David, shared my German-Jewish heritage and had been at Harvard Business School at the same time as me. That unexpected connection led to a friendship, and Lory and I were grateful to host them in Zürich and Klosters before David's death from GBM.

I encountered it again through the Berkshire Hathaway ecosystem. After Berkshire's 2006 acquisition of Iscar, I traveled to Israel with Whitney Tilson to visit the company and I became friends with Eitan Wertheimer, the son of founder Stef Wertheimer. Eitan, who served as CEO after his father and before handing the reins to Jacob Harpaz, also died of brain cancer.

Even within the VALUEx community, the disease has struck close to home: Vitaliy Katsenelson's mother, Irene, and Robert Leitz's father, Siegfried, both succumbed to GBM.

I am writing about this because I want to change that empty-bathtub dynamic. It is possible that through my networks, this letter might lead to something that either cures me or prolongs

my life. At the very least, it may simply direct attention toward a cure that benefits others, even if it does not happen in my lifetime.

I am aware that it is hard for anyone to know all the research that is out there. With the advent of AI and other new tools, a solution to this might not come from existing cancer research but from other fields entirely.

So, if anything in this letter prompts you to want to connect me with new therapies or research, please do get in touch. However, I must ask you to follow a very specific protocol: Do not send these ideas to me. Instead, please reach out to my wife, Lory, or to Chantal.

I have received many expressions of concern, and I truly appreciate them, but here is the reality: Every expression of concern reminds me of what I have, rather than allowing me to live my life. The same is true of miracle cures.

Every other day, I receive a message about a keto diet, stem cell therapy, or a new immunotherapy. I know these are sent with the best of intentions. Nobody intends to cause upset but for me, it means being reminded constantly—every single day—that I have a disease and that there may be “something else” I should be doing. Sometimes these messages come with a certain insistence: “Have you tried this yet?”

While I appreciate you thinking of me, this can actually do damage. Instead of being able to take a break from my diagnosis and engage with a friend about an investment idea, due diligence, or a holiday, I am pulled back into the role of a patient. Sometimes, I just want to be your friend again.

Please know that the research and ideas you send to Chantal or Lory will not be ignored. I have an excellent medical team at Hirslanden clinic, which is affiliated with the University of Zürich right down the road, with connections to the leading cancer centers in the world.

MY MEDICAL TEAM

I am fortunate to have a world-class medical team helping me. At Hirslanden, I am profoundly grateful to Professor Nikolai J. Hopf, who has now peered into my functioning brain three times. There is a unique, sacred trust that forms when you allow a surgeon to do that, never knowing exactly what functionality will remain when you wake up. Alongside him, Professor Uwe Schlegel has been invaluable in guiding me through the complexities of neurology and neuro-oncology, as was Professor Nils Peters in my original diagnosis. My radiotherapy and daily oncological care have been expertly managed by Dr. Cristina Picardi and Dr. Jonas Klöpfer at Onkozentrum Zürich.

I have also been able to consult with some of the finest minds and leading researchers in the field. They include Professor Karl Schaller and Professor Denis Migliorini at Geneva University Hospitals (HUG), who provided crucial guidance. Professor Felix Sahm at University Hospital Heidelberg was very kind and took time to talk through his findings with me. In New York, Professor Theodore Schwartz at Weill Cornell offered his expertise. At the University Hospital in Münster, Professor Walter Stummer, Associate Professor Michael Mütter, and Dr. Niklas Benedikt Pepper have all contributed their knowledge.

I must also mention Professor Roger Stupp in Chicago and at the University Hospital Zurich (USZ). I also owe much to the leadership of Professor Michael Weller, as well as Dr. Tobias Weiss, who leads the CSF laboratory and has been at the forefront of the research into my specific case.

These doctors and their teams review every research paper, diet recommendation, and therapy idea that Chantal or Lory forward to them. They and their students read them to see if they apply to my case or to their other patients. There is a lot of data you don't see—detailed brain scans, drug dose adjustments based on swelling, and other variables. To receive a miracle cure from the internet without that context is not helpful.

THE POWER OF FRIENDSHIP

Douglas Murray has written, in the context of the October 7th massacres, that sometimes a flare goes up, and you see *exactly* where everyone is standing. My cancer diagnosis was one of those flares. When things fall apart, you discover who your friends really are—a crisis has a way of illuminating what was always there.

I have been blessed with many who showed up without hesitation. Not everyone knew how to, and that is understandable—but what has stayed with me are the people who turned out to have extraordinary reserves of kindness and presence.

Some people instinctively run *into* the fire. Bryan Lawrence and Gillian Segal and Naama Baram did just that. Others dropped everything to travel and visit: Li Lu flew in from Seattle, Mohnish Pabrai from Austin, Bonnie and Arthur Fish from Toronto, Adam Franks from London and Ken Shubin Stein from New York, as did John Mihaljevic, Danny Aegerter and others in Zurich. Their physical presence meant far more than they realized.

The World Minds community showed up in force. Rolf Dobelli was present for one of my focal seizures and didn't flinch. Kipper Blakeley, Simone Schürle, Laura Baudis, and Ashkan Nikeghbali have each shown up when it mattered, demonstrating the depth of connection that network has fostered. Dan Ariely spent an entire day with me after the World Minds annual meeting, offering not just his friendship but the kind of understanding that comes from someone who has experienced life-altering tragedy at a young age.

Here in Zürich, our family is a member of the Chabad Jewish community. Mendel Rosenfeld and his son-in-law Nochum have been extraordinarily kind, visiting at short notice. And when Scholom—Mendel's brother—arranged a community Shabbat, he said words that brought me to tears: "*You do what the doctors tell you to do—but only the Almighty knows your fate.*"

Then there are those who simply read about my diagnosis and reached out with a kind word. Atul Gawande, who wrote about me in *The Checklist Manifesto*, reached out after reading my earlier letter. I had not known he followed my annual updates. So did Nicholas Christakis and Amar Bhide. All offered medical insight, humanity, and perspective at a moment when I needed all three. Nick Sleep reached out as well, which touched me deeply.

Janet Echelman, whose husband David died from GBM, has been a steady presence, offering the wisdom and empathy that only someone who has been through it can provide. And Tom Lines helped me and Lory navigate the Swiss medical landscape, as did Ajay Desai (from

Bakersfield) when it came to knowledge of radiology and alternate therapies.

I know that this is just the tip of the iceberg. There many who reached out to Lory including Richard and Katherine Bergin, John Meckert, Peter Hornick, Valerie and Jeremy Lack, Jean-Marc Brunschwig, Marnin Michaels, Nikolai Ahrens, Katrina Smith, Sudha Chennuru, Monita Singh, Julie Meyer, and others.

Lory and I are deeply grateful to the many friends who have supported us—through emotional encouragement, by connecting us with physicians, and by drawing Lory's attention to treatments that might help me. Their kindness meant a great deal during a difficult time, and it reminded us, especially Lory, that we were not facing this alone.

To each of you, Lory and I simply say: thank you—for your friendship with me and with Lory, and for being there when we needed you.

We are equally grateful to those who reached out via Chantal and to Team Aquamarine—Chantal, David, Mariana, and Paaras, and our directors Roland Gysi and Andreas Mikos. You have managed the transition with extraordinary professionalism but have also been present as friends, not just colleagues.

It is only when the ground shifts beneath you that you learn who will steady you, and I have been steadied by more people than I could have ever hoped for.

HOW TO TALK ABOUT HEALTH TO SOMEONE WHO IS SICK

One more thing: If you want to understand how to talk to someone who's sick, read Letty Pogrebin's, *How to Be a Friend to a Friend Who's Sick*. There is an excellent *Wall Street Journal* review, or I can send you a copy if I have extras.

Pogrebin writes: "For a sick friend, first do no harm." The basic idea is that a lot of normal conversation is just inappropriate or does damage when you're talking to somebody who's either sick or terminally ill. For example, if one person asks me how I am, that's fine, but if I have 10 people a day asking me how I am, and I need to respond to every single one, that can be very difficult. What can help is to say, "Just thinking of you," without requiring me to respond.

If you want to get in touch with me about things that are of common interest, things outside of my medical situation that allow me to live my life to the fullest, then that's great. But if you have medical suggestions, please send them to Lory or to Chantal.

LESSONS LEARNED. WISDOM BUMP

The lessons learned from my medical issues to date have been huge, although, like one of Christina Rossetti's protagonists in her poem *Goblin Market*, I would rather be innocent than have the experience of my disease. However, it's certainly been a wisdom bump. Here are some lessons I've learned:

1. Live your best life. You don't know what is going to happen tomorrow, so if there is something you always wanted to do, go ahead and do it.

2. Whatever gifts nature gave you, use them. Don't have any shame. So long as you are not doing damage to yourself or anyone else, go on and enjoy them. I used to look disparagingly on people who used their looks to get ahead. No longer. Whatever gifts you have, you should use them. So if someone is good-looking but not too smart, they should just go for it and use their looks. Don't let anyone make you feel guilty.
3. Delete envious people. They have nothing to be envious of because they don't know what will come tomorrow. I had a couple of people in my life who were envious of me for my good fortune. That made me feel guilty. They sensed that guilt, and as a consequence felt justified in their envy. It was not healthy. I have now deleted them from my life. I should have done it a lot sooner.
4. Time. The medium term does not exist for me any more. There are only two kinds of time: The ever present now, and the eternal. I only do things that make sense on those two scales of time. The medium term is not interesting.
5. Keep a positive attitude and don't complain. I've tried all the other things and they don't work.
6. Meditation—it's not worth it. For me, meditation activates the reptilian freeze mechanism, so it is counter-productive. What works for me is movement and curiosity. When it comes to movement, any kind works: Walking, cross-country skiing, the rowing machine. When I am too tired, I engage my seeking instinct, sometimes by playing chess but mostly by reading. Novels, classics, newspapers, philosophy, history, physics, and mathematics—I am into all of them.
7. My wife and children think that I am courageous. I'm not so sure. I don't like my circumstances but I don't have much choice so I can hardly be courageous. What I do know is that the love I feel from my wife, my children, my family, and friends gives me the courage to make the best of what I have been given. Without that love, everything would be infinitely more difficult.
8. Lastly, when it comes to the reward for all this suffering, I have learned that there are no medals, nor are any medals required. Where there is life there is hope: I learned that from my father, who probably read it in Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings* or in the writings of Cicero. The reward for being here is just that: Being here. To be one of the 100 billion or so humans who have ever lived, to be here today, to simply be here to see it all unfold.

HINENI

In closing there is a Hebrew word I keep coming back to: *Hineni*. It means "Here I am." But it also means so much more.

It appears in the Hebrew Bible at moments of profound testing. When God calls Abraham to sacrifice his son, Abraham responds, "Hineni." And as they walk up the mountain and Isaac calls out, "Father," Abraham answers him with the same word: "Hineni, my son."

It also appears when Moses hears the call of God before the burning bush, and when Isaiah volunteers for his mission. In every instance, *Hineni* signifies that the protagonist is ready to do what the Almighty asks—before he even knows what will be asked.

In a sense, Hineni is the act of letting go of the script you wrote for yourself and accepting the one that is being written for you. I find myself saying Hineni now. Here I am. I don't know what comes next, but I am here to meet it. My task has shifted. For 28 years, my job was to compound your capital. That is no longer my primary task. The task now is to confront what has been given to me—without complaint.

Sometimes the music you prepared to play isn't the music you're called to play. There is a moment that captures this perfectly: The pianist Maria João Pires is seated at the Royal Concertgebouw in Amsterdam. As Riccardo Chailly leads the orchestra into Mozart's Piano Concerto No. 20, you see her jolt—she had prepared a different concerto entirely. There is a split second of visible fear, and then she steadies herself, turns to the keyboard, and plays the correct concerto brilliantly.

That is where I am. I was prepared to play the music of compounding capital for decades to come, but that is not the music I have been given. And—unlike Maria Pires at the Concertgebouw—there is no score, so I will have to improvise, to the best of my ability.

Hineni. Here I am.

With warm wishes,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Guy Spier', followed by a horizontal line.

Guy Spier

